



What comes after post-Soviet? Towards a new concept of de-Sovietization in higher education and research

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ABSTRACT

For almost three decades, scholars sought to understand the transformations of higher education systems previously subjected to totalitarian Soviet control. Early attempts to investigate post-Soviet reforms provided limited explanations of the chaotic and challenging nature of these transformations, inducing a valid critique of the dominant interpretation of the post-Soviet changes as a unidirectional transition from the party/state-dominated model to a Western market-oriented system. The processes of deconstructing the Soviet legacy have remained under-studied, while post-Soviet research in education largely accepts the legitimization and even re-integration of the past. By drawing on existing theoretical and empirical scholarship, this article explains why a new conceptualization of de-Sovietization is needed in higher education research and why the processes of re-envisioning values, practices, and institutions in the post-Soviet education and research are necessary to promote critical inquiry, academic freedom, and scholars' agential responsibilities.

1. Introduction

The concept of de-Sovietization is relatively new in the literature on global higher education. The initial studies of post-Soviet transformations, which were conducted in the first decade after the collapse of the Soviet Union, had inconsequential continuation and wavering interest in the following twenty years. The growing influence of global neoliberalism spearheaded simplistic interpretations of transformations across a wide territory, which was variably called "post-Soviet space," "Eurasia," "former Soviet (or Russian) empire." These interpretations often implied a unidirectional transition from the party/state-dominated model to a Western-style market-oriented system (Heyneman, 1998, 2010; Huisman et al., 2018). Moreover, the post-socialist studies of education paid little attention to the peculiarities of university transformations and its reproductive powers (Silova, 2011). Research on post-Soviet academia was often obstructed by self-preserving elites and traditions of self-censorship (Jonbekova, 2015). Research on the world-class university movement has generated interest in higher education reforms but barely looked into the challenges of the Soviet legacy (Hladchenko et al., 2016; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018). While some insights can be derived from disparate trajectories in institutional and system-level changes in various post-Soviet university systems

(Chankseliani et al., 2022; Leisyte et al., 2019; Tomusk, 2004), the concept of de-Sovietization remains a work in progress, and a more nuanced understanding of motifs of and resistance to the deconstruction of the Soviet legacy is necessary (Chankseliani, 2022; Kuzhabekova and Ruby, 2018; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018).

Currently, a conceptual dearth in this domain is paramount. Chankseliani (2022) argues that de-Sovietization studies need to consider the dialectical nature of changes in the former Soviet republics, leading some states (e.g., Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania) to fully integrate with European higher education, and others (e.g., Belarus, Russia) to resume the Soviet practices of authoritarianism, indoctrination, and surveillance over dissidents. Moreover, the tiptoeing research on the Soviet legacy in higher education, where scholars in the authoritarian regimes obfuscate the problem statements and avoid direct criticism of their governing bodies, has undercut a proper conceptualization of post-soviet reforms (Forrat, 2016; Huisman et al., 2018). The research on de-Sovietization is still evanescent despite efforts to offer noteworthy findings on the abandonment of the Soviet model, followed by neoliberal policies in the Chinese, Russian, Georgian, and Ukrainian higher education contexts (Oleksiyenko, 2023a, 2023b; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018; Shen et al., 2022). This impairs insights into the problems of resentment and resistance to reforms as well as limits mitigation

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strategies. Meanwhile, the agential roles and responsibilities of reformists are often simplified or overlooked (Oleksiyenko, 2023; Smolentseva, 2017). Rethinking the premises of theoretical and empirical scholarship on post-Soviet transformations requires a more critical perspective, and inquiry into the de-Sovietization of higher education is crucial.

We have undertaken an analysis that relies on a mix of philosophical and phenomenological perspectivalizations to elaborate the concept of de-Sovietization in higher education and research. By engaging with the Derridean concepts of decentering and deconstruction, we pursue analytical desegregation of the de-Sovietization phenomenon as a reflexive “lived experience” (given that both authors have personal experience with post-Soviet education and institutions) and as a social construct (as a juxtaposition to deconstruction) in which scholarship and criticism are integrated or rejected by disparate participants of societal changes. The binary of Sovietization and de-Sovietization are not opposites or juxtapositions of unification versus diversification in transformation approaches. Instead, we argue that de-Sovietization evolves as a longitudinal deconstruction where legacy-holders sustain rather than defy a deformity of previous systemic and institutional designs of academia and thus retain various degrees of temporal and spatial engagements with the lingering traditions of closed society, rigid structuration, and uncritical thinking. While examining the processes and problems of de-Sovietization, we try to distinguish between reorientations and rigidities in post-Soviet higher education. Jacques Derrida’s perspective on deconstruction as unpeeling of interpretative layers in the logocentric discourse urges us to delve deeper into post-Soviet discourses on legacy and change while questing for more insightful critique in the conceptualization of post-Soviet transformations.

2. Soviet legacies and post-Soviet transformations

Historically, the Soviet legacy is aberrant in the eyes of the advocates of Humboldtian traditions of higher education. To streamline ideological indoctrination and militarist industrialization across the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR), the Bolsheviks designed a higher education model (a.k.a., the Socialist System of Professional Workforce Training) based on “army-style” uniformity, one-man management, and top-down administration (Kuraev, 2016). Soviet policies of centralization, proletarianization, and vocationalization deformed a diverse landscape of pre-Soviet higher education institutions (Huisman et al., 2018; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018). Bolsheviks turned Jesuit colleges, Humboldtian, and Napoleonic-style universities into rigid ideological institutions (Dobbins, 2011) with “unified curricula, the same structure and a common authority” (Kuraev, 2016): 184). The Communist Party of the Soviet Union maintained unilateral control over decision-making in curriculum development and the centralized management of institutions of higher learning, which had “almost no autonomy or academic freedom” (Chankseliani, 2022): 27). Oleksiyenko (2021) argues that it is the concept of “surrogate academic freedom,” which emerged over time as a form of post-truth politicking in the hyper-regulated environment, that urged academics to “escape from moral norms of truth-seeking, honesty, responsibility” (ibid, p. 1117). In the context of full political control over staff recruitment and student admissions, the structure and content of university teaching and research (if any) were shaped by periodic purges of “bourgeois intellectuals” (Bertelsen and Shkandrij, 2014; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018; Shlapentokh, 1990; Tromly, 2013). Moreover, the Soviet leadership used higher education as a colonizing instrument to promote the superiority of Russia in other republics. The Bolsheviks re-introduced imperial Russification policies, including imposing Russian as the medium of teaching and research, rewriting textbooks to present ideologically appropriate narratives (Chankseliani, 2017), and resettling Russian scholars to advance the assimilation of indigenous populations (Applebaum, 1994; Chankseliani, 2022).

The failure of the Soviet system to sustain the totalitarian regime led

to the emergence of newly independent states in 1990–1991. The Soviet collapse allowed for rapid nationalization of curricula and research agendas in most post-Soviet countries, which at times conflicted with neoliberal reformers’ pursuit of quick absorption and assimilation of Western liberal values (Heyneman, 1998; Silova, 2015). The reformist dynamics differed across regions – for example, the Baltic republics were moving away from the Soviet legacy faster than their Central Asian counterparts (Silova, 2011). In some countries, such as Ukraine, unable to design original systems and institutions, the colonial thinkers argued that some Soviet traditions were part of the national heritage (Oleksiyenko, 2022). However, the advancement of market ideology and economic globalization urged post-Soviet systems to join the movement of neoliberal transformations, which some perceived as an opportunity to “normalize” their higher education systems and “catch up” with the West (Gvaramadze, 2010; Huisman et al., 2018; Kopecký, 2018; Tomusk, 2004). Tomusk (2004) argued that the perception of liberalism’s victory over communism encouraged many thinkers to adopt a unidirectional perspective about progress (see, for example, (Fukuyama, 1992). Most independent states that emerged from the USSR (except for Belarus and several countries in Central Asia) rushed to develop market economies and promote a democratic political order. Snyder (2022) argues, however, that naïve enthusiasm for capitalist ascendancy led many to overlook the corrupt elites and kleptocratic tendencies in the post-Soviet space. While market rhetoric stirred up demand for new skills and broader access to higher education so individuals could tackle “occupational uncertainty typical for a market not a planned economy” (Heyneman, 1998): 24), it did not encourage critical thinking and vigilance with regard to corruption (Heyneman, 2010). Meanwhile, growing access to low-quality higher education and the rising number of degree mills only intensified the precarity of university graduates (Huisman et al., 2018).

Moreover, Soviet-style marketization managed on the basis of the feudal relations and “one-man management” of the previous era had unintended consequences for faculty recruitment and retention policies. The academic profession lost its former symbolic prestige and became poorly compensated, leading to an unprecedented brain drain (Chankseliani, 2022; Tomusk, 2004). Confluent crises (e.g., political transition, economic decline, armed conflicts in some newly independent states) further deprived post-Soviet academia of already limited local capacity to perform reforms (Heyneman, 2000; Nižov and Silova, 2020; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018), while encouraging “uncritical submission to Western experts and nonexperts ... as the easiest and most cost-efficient way of reaching world higher education standards” (Tomusk, 2004): 79). Governments of newly independent states engaged with international agencies (e.g., International Monetary Fund, World Bank) for the sake of generating extra revenue (and engaging in corrupt schemes) rather than to implement reforms in earnest (Heyneman, 2010). While eleven countries joined the European higher education harmonization project (a.k.a., Bologna process) to transform their post-Soviet higher education systems by implementing changes in policies and institutional structures, their engagement with reforms was often superficial and contentious (Chankseliani et al., 2021; Heyneman, 2010; Heyneman and Skinner, 2014; Huisman, 2019). Despite the good intentions of the reformers, the Soviet legacy-holders proved to be resilient in sustaining a self-serving and punitive bureaucracy, as universities resisted reforms and their staff remained aligned with authoritarian forms of governance (Chankseliani, 2022; Chankseliani et al., 2021; Oleksiyenko, 2021; Oleksiyenko, 2023; Ubaydullaeva, 2022).

Nonetheless, higher education institutions that once constituted the Socialist System of Professional Workforce Training underwent heterogeneous transformations, leading the national systems to further diverge from one another. Regional affiliations (e.g., the Baltics, Caucasus, Central Asia, Eastern Europe) also shaped new cultural dynamics and references. As the divergences multiplied, scholarship grew increasingly critical of efforts to find universal theories and approaches persistently appearing in “post-Soviet” studies (Chankseliani, 2022), while

questioning the validity of the modernization theory, which is often perceived as advancing colonialism (Gewirtz, 2017; Tomusk, 2004). The emergence of post-Soviet higher education as fifteen varying systems (Antonowicz et al., 2017; Chankseliani, 2022; Chankseliani et al., 2022; Huisman et al., 2018) challenges commonly held assumptions about the unidirectionality of progress and the validity of “one-size-fits-all” interventions. Oleksiyenko and Li recommended delving deeper and more critically into the concept of de-Sovietization when intending “to describe the transformation of academia once under the sway of the Kremlin-controlled totalitarian regime” (Oleksiyenko et al., 2018): 8). Using the Derridean framework of deconstruction, we only further reinstate the importance of uncovering new meanings in the process of truth-seeking. Moreover, in investigating de-Sovietization, we emphasize the importance of resisting the tendencies to rationalize path-dependencies and reform failures in view of authoritarian intimidations (Froumin and Lisutkin, 2018; Jonbekova, 2015; Ubaydullaeva, 2022).

3. Defining de-Sovietization as divergence in legacy re-envisioning

De-Sovietization is the process of re-envisioning values, practices, and institutions (Chankseliani, 2022) in pursuit of aspirations to overturn authoritarian and repressive political and educational legacies (Oleksiyenko et al., 2018). For many researchers in the field, this aim has acquired heightened significance in the past two years, as re-envisioning (*переосмислення*) emerged as a dominant theme in Ukrainian academic and public discourses affected by the genocidal attack launched by the Russian Federation in February 2022. Russia's war started in 2014 with the annexation of Crimea and the invasion of the Donbas (Plokhyy, 2023). Yet, the broader and deeper sense of re-imagined turmoil grew over time (for many, only after the 2022 watershed moment), notwithstanding attempts undertaken earlier to disclose problematic agendas (see, for example, (Dyak and Sklokina, 2016); (Nahlik, 2015); (Posokhov and Rachkov, 2022)). Indeed, it takes time, as Chankseliani (2022) notes, to engage with legacies while “[f]acing the past and making sense of it ... to understand and critically engage with the present and for imagining the future” (ibid, p. 141). While re-envisioning may facilitate the deconstruction of the Soviet legacy for higher education stakeholders seeking to deliberately depart from Soviet practices (Oleksiyenko et al., 2018), de-Sovietization is often culturally specific (Shen et al., 2022) and is subject to pre-determined frames of analyses (Chankseliani, 2022).

Previously, Oleksiyenko et al. (2018) positioned de-Sovietization on a continuum with Sovietization to juxtapose the army-style organization (Kuraev, 2016) with the Humboldtian model of the research-oriented university advocating for the freedoms to teach, learn, and govern. Ontologically, de-Sovietization entails transforming higher education institutions from rigid state-run organizations into autonomous colleges and universities with diverse structures and purposes. In practice, we indeed saw novel institutions emerging in the post-Soviet space. For instance, the rise of private universities stimulated more entrepreneurial and autonomous development while disrupting the Soviet landscape of hyper-regulated institutes (Dakowska and Harmsen, 2015; Huisman et al., 2018; Tomusk, 2004). In the post-communist countries of Eastern Europe and the Baltic Republics, the state's function has changed from higher education provider to market regulator (Dobbins and Khatryan, 2015; Tomusk, 2004), with increasingly limited capacity to maintain uniformity among public institutions demanding more autonomy (Leisyte et al., 2019). Yet, the countries of Eurasia (e.g., Belarus, Russia, and Central Asia) continued to nurture state-centered higher education (Abdrasheva and Sabzalieva, 2023; Gille-Belova, 2015). While reformists strived to identify a context-appropriate level of university autonomy and state regulation, the legacy-holders who relied on governmental control and resource distribution systems were often strong enough to promote centralized regulation. In some instances,

universities gained autonomy to make their own decisions on governance, academics, and finance.

Indeed, national culture and historical legacies had a marked impact on institutional transformations. For example, Lithuanian universities, with strong historical links to European traditions, were more inclined to rejoin the European Area of Higher Education and became non-profit organizations, reporting to the parliament (Kopecký, 2018). In Central Asia, the universities fully followed the logic of their central governments – either ambitious Westernization (or Europeanization) projects and engagement with global competition, as was observed in Nazarbayev's Kazakhstan (Lodhi and Ilyassova-Schoenfeld, 2023), or disparagement of internationalization, as was observed in Karimov's Uzbekistan (Ubaydullaeva, 2022). Resistance to internationalization was also observed in Ukraine, where under influences of Russian orthodoxy, the government took a hierarchical approach and maintained relatively strict regulations over universities while often paying lip service to the Bologna Process (Shevchenko, 2019) or cultivating “academic tourism” (Oleksiyenko et al., 2023). Meanwhile, the top-down management was justified by fear of lawlessness (Dobko, 2013). In reality, the growth of degree mills that facilitated revenue generation from local and international students (Oleksiyenko, 2021), as well as access to publicly-owned facilities and lands that were of interest to local oligarchs, motivated corrupt powerbrokers to keep the budgets of public universities under strict governmental oversight (Kvit, 2020; Oleksiyenko, 2023). Nonetheless, it could be argued that state control over universities diminished from time to time during major crises. This allowed the government to shun its subsidization responsibilities. It also enabled universities to find better strategies to manage crises (Oleksiyenko et al., 2022). Thus, during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020–2022 and Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022–2023, some Ukrainian universities ventured into diversifying their technological means and methodologies while spearheading a “community of online and offline participants studying and discussing critical issues and concerns across cultures and continents” (Oleksiyenko et al., 2023): 1114).

Epistemologically, de-Sovietization implies refuting the Soviet binary logic (Chankseliani, 2022) that sustained a divide between capitalist and socialist scholarship (Shen et al., 2022). Soviet epistemology of ideology (Tlostanova, 2015) implied a literal interpretation of “scientific socialism,” meaning that “most questions had already been answered, most theories tested. The purpose of education, then, was to transfer the results. Physics and chemistry were not open testable and malleable theories, but rather illustrations for socialist achievement” (Heyneman, 1992): 36). The collapse of the USSR deprived Marxism-Leninism of its ideological monopoly (Heyneman, 2000; Shparaga and Minakov, 2019). Consequently, de-Sovietization required transforming post-Soviet higher education institutions into spaces of critical inquiry where comprehensive engagement with a plurality of theoretical and conceptual traditions would be welcomed (Shen et al., 2022). For instance, in China, teaching and research on economics changed significantly through engagement with economists in both capitalist and socialist countries, leading to an increased focus on economic theory and empirical evidence rather than on “political imperatives” (Gewirtz, 2017): 27). Nevertheless, in Russia, efforts have been made to reinforce dogmatism and defy critical or alternative thinking, as exemplified by Oleksiyenko et al. (2018):

... the extreme censorship of ideas in Russia has even led to events such as book burnings – for example, after the Kremlin put a ban on the activities of the American philanthropist George Soros in Russia, one college campus incinerated books that had been published with support from the Open Society Foundations (formerly Open Society Institute), a non-governmental organization that has been a major supporter of social sciences and humanities projects in the post-Soviet space (ibid, p. 4)

Indeed, the cultural and epistemological legacies of knowledge production make de-Sovietization far from being unidirectional or irreversible. The shape of post-Soviet higher education depends on local contexts and political environments, which may encourage resistance to the demolition of deep-seated legacies. The “resumption of the Soviet regulative, cultural, and relational templates” may be of interest to local elites and their entrenched traditions and discourses (Oleksiienko et al., 2018): 15). Geopolitically, re-Sovietization is amplified by the Russian government, which seeks opportunities to influence educational decision-making in neighboring countries, as well as to mold new generations of Russia-friendly local elites through branch campuses and scholarships (Chankseliani, 2021; Oleksiienko et al., 2018; Westad, 2005). Ultimately, Russian re-Sovietization efforts have been seen as attempts to re-claim Moscow’s central role in the region, which has been consistently challenged after the former Soviet states gained independence (Oleksiienko et al., 2018).

4. Decentering post-Soviet higher education and research

The collapse of the USSR in 1991 caused a rapture in the formerly hyper-centralized higher education system, allowing it to open up to the influences of globalization, marketization, and liberalization (Chankseliani, 2022; Huisman et al., 2018; Oleksiienko et al., 2018). The dissolution of the center of reference that imposed totality on the overall structure of Soviet higher education presented an existential threat to the system. Derrida (1970) argued that in such circumstances, discourse may take over the maintenance of structurality. However, discourse is known to have a limited capacity to impose totality on all parts of the system, leading to the emergence of a freer structure and decentering. Indeed, “[t]he emancipation from the confines of communism” enabled previously isolated systems to engage with Western higher education practices (Dobbins, 2011): 4) and draw on the states’ pre-Soviet past to identify historically legitimate models of tertiary education and research (Dobbins, 2011; Tomusk, 2004). Each national government strove to develop its vision for newly liberated higher education in order to align it with the needs of the emerging nation-state (Huisman et al., 2018; Kopecký, 2018). Meanwhile, Russia, which some analysts claim is an empire-state rather than a nation-state, attempted to maintain its influence over the former Soviet republics (Chankseliani, 2021; Oleksiienko et al., 2018). Russian overbearing and aggressive policies and military interventions alienated scholars in most post-Soviet countries over time (Oleksiienko, 2023).

Decentering in post-Soviet higher education and research can be argued to have evolved in three distinct modes: Soviet-centric, Eurocentric, and nation-centric. While these can be at times viewed as being intertwined, especially in countries undergoing slow and inefficient reforms, as has been observed, for example, in Georgia, Ukraine or Uzbekistan (Hladchenko et al., 2018; Oleksiienko, 2022; Oleksiienko, 2023; Shevchenko, 2019; Ubaydullaeva, 2022), more comprehensive understanding of these competing and overlapping modes is helpful in conceptualizing transformative trajectories and deformities in different higher education systems. Let’s have a look at each mode.

A Soviet-centric mode retained legitimacy in the majority of USSR republics when major ideological cadres were allowed to hold on to their positions while allegedly changing their orientation to free-market liberalism or nationalism. Tomusk (2004) suggests that the communist regime managed to dictate the terms of judgment for its legacy, including its crimes, by taking control over the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Since it was the communist legislatures that negotiated political changes, the former Soviet nomenklatura had set the rules for marketization and democratization, and enjoyed privileged opportunities for accumulating symbolic and economic capital through insider knowledge (Tomusk, 2006). For instance, high-ranking communist party officials were elected presidents in Azerbaijan and Georgia (Chankseliani, 2022), Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, and Ukraine (Johnson, 2008; Plokhý, 2015; Ubaydullaeva, 2022). The leadership and

faculty members of higher education institutions often preserved their positions without bearing responsibility for their roles in mono-ideological knowledge production, Marxist-Leninist indoctrination of students, and collaboration with the Soviet security services. The success of former communist cadres in the independent states provided legitimacy for the Soviet legacy in higher education (Hladchenko et al., 2020; Tomusk, 2006). Thus, Soviet legacy-holders have maintained a romanticized image of Soviet academia by highlighting its achievements in science and technology (e.g., space travel, nuclear weapons, computer systems) (Heyneman, 2000) in full awareness that “[a]ny restructuring of powers in society and within academia [can be] a threat to their legitimacy and authority” (Oleksiienko, 2023): 55).

However, in some post-Soviet contexts, historical legitimacy was also drawn from the pre-communist past of higher education institutions encouraging Eurocentric reforms, which promised more freedom, new opportunities for international engagement, and funding, increasingly necessary in the context of diminishing state expenditures on higher education and research across the region (Chankseliani, 2022; Dobbins and Kwiek, 2017; Oleksiienko et al., 2023; Tomusk, 2004). In Armenia, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Russia, and Ukraine, some universities were established following the European university tradition before the formation of the USSR (Chankseliani, 2022). These institutions enabled the engagement of local intellectuals with other scholars across Europe (Dobbins, 2011; Hladchenko et al., 2020). After World War II, the Soviet Union expanded westward, incorporating Humboldtian universities with the occupation of the Baltic states and expansion of the borders of the Ukrainian SSR to include Lviv and Chernivtsi universities (Chankseliani, 2022; Hladchenko et al., 2020). However, through repressions, censorship, and isolation, Sovietization limited knowledge about higher education’s pre-Soviet legacies (Connelly, 2014; Dobbins and Khachatryan, 2015). After the collapse of the Soviet Union, the constituent republics made deliberate efforts to distance themselves from the Soviet heritage, and Eurocentric policies were among the instruments for the transformation of higher education. While the Baltic states engaged in higher education Europeanization as a part of their broader EU integration process (Dakowska and Harmsen, 2015), governments in Eastern Europe, Caucasus, and Kazakhstan joined the Bologna process (Heyneman and Skinner, 2014; Huisman, 2019; Kobakhidze and Samniashvili, 2022; Lodhi and Ilyassova-Schoenfeld, 2023). Eurocentric harmonization reached even Central Asian states formally not a party to the Bologna process. For instance, Kyrgyzstan’s involvement with the EU-funded Tempus program has largely focused on aligning the state’s “higher education system with Bologna reforms” (Merrill, 2011): 12).

Meanwhile, a nation-centric mode was pursued, occasionally driven by governments and universities seeking to defy rather than support international influences (Gille-Belova, 2015; Oleksiienko, 2023; Ubaydullaeva, 2022). The former Soviet republics were preoccupied with “(re-)establishing their national identities which either had never existed before, or were undermined throughout Soviet colonial rule and had to be entirely rethought” (Chankseliani, 2022): 78). Paradoxically, institutions of higher education that served the communist regime and exposed “bourgeois nationalism” had to recalibrate to serve newly independent nation-states (Oleksiienko, 2014) preoccupied with the establishment of a shared sense of citizenship (Heyneman, 1998). For the former Soviet periphery, Russia’s political, linguistic, and cultural domination presented an obstacle to the national (re-)awakening. Thus, some states engaged in decolonization attempts, urging academics and administrators of tertiary institutions to transition to using the local language(s) in teaching and research, had to rethink historical figures and narratives that had been constructed (or perverted) by the Bolsheviks (Huisman et al., 2018; Oleksiienko, 2022). Such re-interpretations were driven by different predispositions for critical inquiry. Dobbins (2011) argues that countries with a developed pre-communist Humboldtian tradition have been able to take advantage of the moment of change to re-establish academic self-governance and academic freedom, while states lacking a consolidated academic community maintained

highly centralized higher education systems and prescriptive narratives. Indeed, this was observed in Belarus, where the authoritarian regime instrumentalized accreditation to limit independent higher education activities and critical thinking (Huisman et al., 2018; Tomusk, 2004). The Belarusian accreditation required that all institutions follow governmentally approved standards, which regulated the content of the study programs in a rather Soviet manner by prescribing courses to be taught to students, the number of hours to be dedicated to each course, and even issues discussed in a class (Tomusk, 2004). In the 2000 s, Lukashenko's government reinstated control over rectors' appointments at private and public higher education institutions (Gille-Belova, 2015; Huisman et al., 2018).

Decentering in three distinct directions breeds tensions between the new centers of reference, making de-Sovietization a dialectical process involving "chaotic, contradictory forces within institutions and societies" (Chankseliani, 2022): 4). The Soviet legacy-holders focus on maintaining existing discourses, preserving structurality, and resisting change and innovation. Heyneman (1998) observed that counter-reform efforts "seem to rest upon the "need for stability," national pride..., suspicion of foreigners, discreditation of comparative education evidence, and the rise of sectarian ethnocentrism" (ibid, p. 26). Eurocentric actors, internal and external, seek to challenge the Soviet legacy. Meanwhile, nationally oriented stakeholders may cooperate with one of the other groups to prevent others from achieving their goals. For instance, nationally focused actors in Ukraine see in the Soviet legacy the danger of Russification, which encourages their support for some Western-driven reforms. However, they occasionally may cooperate with the Soviet legacy-holders against Western-oriented reformers due to fear that globalization will undermine the national project (Oleksiyenko, 2023). In contrast, Estonian nation-centric actors saw their interests aligning with Eurocentrics, promoting accession to the EU, allowing to build momentum for a swifter transformation (Stevick, 2015). Yet, even in this context, some reforms have been discussed by scholars as a mere "lip service" performed to avoid changes to the routinized practices (Kopecký, 2018). Thus, de-Sovietization appears as eclectic, given that diverse centers of reference enable inconsistent and inconsequential deconstruction of the Soviet legacy in higher education and research.

5. Deconstructing Soviet values, practices, and institutions

De-Sovietization entails deconstructing the values, practices, and institutions that sustain and circulate the discourse, enabling the Soviet legacy to persist. Mills (2004) argued that "discourse is not a disembodied collection of statements..." (p. 10) but is organized around practices, institutions, and social contexts that maintain it. Certainly, these elements are tightly interconnected, and the separate analysis of each in this section is a theoretical exercise. However, it is helpful to flesh out the elements undergoing deconstruction in the process of de-Sovietization to demonstrate the relationship between them. Deconstruction allows us to penetrate the limits and boundaries of "what is present, for the present is precisely what demands endless analysis, criticism, and deconstruction" (Derrida and Caputo, 1997): 41) and to open up to the other "to what it promises to become: to provide a chance or an opening for the invention" (ibid, p. 44).

Deconstruction impels the lifting of any restrictions "to wonder about any improbability" (Derrida and Caputo, 1997): 51), allowing for the questioning of inconsistent concepts and logic governing post-Soviet higher education and research systems. In post-Soviet academia, freedom has been utilized to avoid choice and responsibility. "The absolutist view of freedom was portrayed as outweighing, in terms of importance, the ethical dilemmas behind the question of choice," enabling an "ethics-free mode of thinking" (Oleksiyenko, 2021): 1121) that facilitates "... moral corruption and the persistent dual morality" (Tomusk, 2004): 196). In such an environment, few researchers have the courage and capacity to perform critical inquiry. Epistemological

rigidity is normalized by discourse regurgitating the myth of the USSR's excellence in higher education and scholarship, as demonstrated by its achievements in the natural sciences (Heyneman, 2000; Tomusk, 2004). This discourse allows scholars to avoid critical reflection on the Soviet culture of performativity, which enabled the proliferation of mediocrity, corruption, and nepotism (Chankseliani et al., 2022; Yurchak, 2006). "[T]he spread of corruption in the education sector has been a shock... This is particularly true in Central Asia. Payments for grades, bribery for entry, corruption in accreditation and licensing now threaten the social cohesion of several Central Asian nations" (Niëzov and Silova, 2020): 10). Post-Soviet scholars utilize patriotic narratives to resist the institutionalization of free competition while maintaining inbreeding and indoctrination (Oleksiyenko et al., 2018). Deconstructing post-Soviet values and practices requires prioritizing responsibility. Responsibility comes from recognizing the unknown, asking questions without restrictions, and challenging ignorance through critical inquiry (Derrida and Caputo, 1997).

Given that rigid institutional structures perpetuate mediocrity, their deconstruction is critical for encouraging creativity and innovations to address the increasingly complex challenges faced by changing post-Soviet societies (Tomusk, 2006). Many post-Soviet states continue supporting the functionalist university model instituted in the USSR to enable student employability and applied research. Thus, these states maintain essentialist views of higher education by prioritizing governments' economic and political agendas over the interests of individuals (Chankseliani et al., 2021). In addition, Soviet administrative-bureaucratic legacies, coupled with neoliberal managerialism, have increased bureaucratic pressure on academic staff. For example, Kuzhabekova and Almukhambetova (Kuzhabekova and Almukhambetova, 2021) found that in Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, the responsibilities of deans, vice-deans, chairs, and their deputies increased substantially, making these positions rather unpopular. Stakhanovite workloads have dampened creativity and innovation (Oleksiyenko, 2022). Young scholars choose to leave the academic profession, being demotivated by excessive teaching and administrative workloads and limited research resources (Dobbins and Khachatryan, 2015; Kuzhabekova et al., 2019). Meanwhile, some researchers even reported experiencing bullying in response to their efforts to share international experiences in post-Soviet universities (Kuzhabekova et al., 2019; Oleksiyenko et al., 2023; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018). Deconstruction makes it possible to challenge the very philosophy of rigid institutions by "making institutions livable—open-ended, porous, and on the *qui vive*—and structured around programs that do not try to program everything" but rather "open the institution to its own future" and, when necessary, encourage the opening of new institutions (Derrida and Caputo, 1997): 50). Arguably, the limited success of attempts to establish world-class universities in the post-Soviet space (Kuzhabekova, 2020; Oleksiyenko et al., 2018) could be attributed to inadequate efforts to deconstruct the Soviet legacy of rigid institutions that continues to hinder the quality of teaching and research activities.

However, the conceptualization of de-Sovietization should not be limited to the analysis of institutional transformations in universities only because changes in other spaces of knowledge production can foster an understanding of the reasons for the legacy's longevity. For example, in addition to higher education institutions, Soviet research infrastructure included industrial institutes and science academies, which housed extensive scholarly activities (Chankseliani et al., 2022). These institutions ensured regime control over the activities of scholars outside of the university (Portnov, 2020). After the collapse of the USSR, some of these institutions remained operational in the post-Soviet states, while others have been transformed (Chankseliani et al., 2022). For instance, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Georgia, and Kazakhstan reformed their science academies into scholarly societies (Chankseliani, 2022; Kopecký, 2018). However, it would be an oversimplification to consider the maintenance of the science academies purely as a Soviet legacy. For example, in Russia and Ukraine, the Academies of Sciences were

established before the Soviet Union (Portnov, 2020; Zayarnyuk and Sereida, 2022). While in Russia, it represents imperial legacy (Avrus, 2001), in Ukraine, the Academy is associated with the early independence period, as well as Soviet heritage. Context-appropriate re-envisioning of these institutions, along with other academic associations, provides opportunities for a more thoughtful de-Sovietization.

6. Re-claiming agency for de-Sovietization

Intentionality in the process of de-Sovietization requires individuals, their collectives, and institutions to exercise agency to bring about change. Soviet organizational principles of “uniformity, top-down administration, and one-man management” (Kuraev, 2016): 183) suppressed individual and institutional agency, paving the way for a post-Soviet drift – a state of inconsistent and ambiguous reforms in many post-Soviet states (Chankseliani, 2022; Hladchenko et al., 2020). De-Sovietization requires the agency to alter routinized practices (e.g., (Kuzhabekova et al., 2019); (Shchepetylnykova, 2023); (Shen et al., 2022)). We observed determined actions by various reformers promoting the Bologna processes, for example, as a way to encourage faster integration of countries like Georgia into the European space of higher education. However, the agency of change was often met by the agency of resistance, as noted earlier. In the context of decentering, resistance breeds tensions with reformers and is sometimes enabled by nationally oriented actors (Dobbins and Khachatryan, 2015; Oleksiyenko, 2023). While both de-Sovietization and resistance to de-Sovietization (or even re-Sovietization) rival each other, a question emerges about the true manifestations of agency, as well as manifestations of freedom, which some legacy-holders see as “academic freedom,” and which critical scholarly reflections defined as “surrogate academic freedom” (Kobakhidze and Samniashvili, 2022; Oleksiyenko, 2021).

Emirbayer and Mische (1998) define agency as the state of “self-hood, motivation, will, purposiveness, intentionality, choice, initiative, freedom, and creativity” (p. 962). Thus, resistance to de-Sovietization and the employment of post-truth politics for that purpose can be interpreted by some scholars as a manifestation of academic freedom (Oleksiyenko and Jackson, 2021). Differentiating between pretensions and genuine manifestations of academic freedom is increasingly difficult amidst the proliferation of post-truth politics (Marini and Oleksiyenko, 2022).

Mills et al. (2009) suggest the need to distinguish between individual, proxy, and collective agencies. A person may exercise individual agency on their own behalf and proxy agency by acting on behalf of someone else. Proxy agency can be evidenced in an administrator's actions on behalf of the institution, faculty, and students. Finally, the collective agency is the result of cooperation among agential individuals. It appears in institutions and organizations (Mills et al., 2009). For example, Marginson and Rhoades (2002) observe it at the level of a department, university, national association, and international organization. While individuals can create whatever they wish for their own benefit or interest, the collective agency often results from negotiated processes and spaces, where individual freedoms can be confronted rather than supplemented by the freedoms of others, and the agency emerges as a duty (of respect, listening, arguing, asking, etc.) through which disparate intentions are brought into compromised agreement and resolution. Instances of leveraging collective agency for de-Sovietization have been observed in Ukraine, where a university consortium pioneered institutional autonomy reforms (Kvit, 2020). Similarly, in Kazakhstan, young researchers established their own professional associations to assist with social integration into the local academic profession, exchange of information, and counteracting networks of Soviet legacy-holders that attempted to monopolize access to resources. Collectively, these young researchers negotiated improvements in employment conditions on the institutional and national levels (Kuzhabekova et al., 2019).

The negotiated agency is vital to reduce the impacts of post-truth

politicizing because it enables tripart orientation in re-envisioning while stimulating “a temporally embedded process of social engagement, informed by the past (in its habitual aspect), but also oriented toward the future (as a capacity to imagine alternative possibilities) and toward the present (as a capacity to contextualize past habits and future projects within the contingencies of the moment)” (Emirbayer and Mische, 1998): 963). Temporal embeddedness of agency allows de-Sovietization actors and institutions to critically engage with others to rethink the Soviet past and interrogate its legacy collectively in the present context while imagining various alternative futures in such “constructing and enabling contexts of action” (ibid, p. 964). Therefore, de-Sovietization calls for more sophisticated investigations of “the relationship between different kinds of agentic processes and particular structuring contexts of action” (ibid, p. 1005) if post-Soviet higher education and research is to be liberated from the legacies of authoritarianism, dogma, and institutional rigidity.

7. Concluding remarks

The concept of de-Sovietization entails a complex process of deconstruction. This deconstruction is not only an upending of the rules and traditions of the previous era but also a removal of controversial interpretative layers of discourses protected by legacy-holders interested in sustaining dogmatic higher education. While modernization-oriented scholars held hope that rejection of the authoritarian regime would depoliticize higher education and research, post-Soviet reforms proved to be complex and sometimes produced inconsequential results, with legacies of the past remaining firmly in place and hindering pro-democratic transformations. As Chankseliani (2022) argues, “[when] old ways of doing things (thesis) are challenged (antithesis) in a struggle, a new state of balance emerges (synthesis) and the tensions are temporarily resolved” (pp. 4–5) – thus creating an illusion of disrupted change, which legacy-holders still prefer to genuine transformation.

Conceptualization of de-Sovietization as a dialectical process involves recognizing interactions between competing centers of reference, where Western and Eastern paradigms of organization and thinking collide. When they acknowledge it to be a complicated process with multiple layers and dynamics of control and change, de-Sovietization scholars offer a more sophisticated perspective on the deconstruction of legacies. Multiple historical, cultural, and socio-political contexts within the post-Soviet space have proved to be more complex than assumed by Western theories. While the 1991 baseline for most former Soviet republics involved decommunization (primarily manifested through the termination of state control and subsequent growth of capitalist markets), disparate forces shaping local and national transformations set the independent states on divergent reform paths. For some on the periphery of the Soviet Empire, where higher education served as a tool for Russification, independence signified an opportunity to overcome the colonial relationship with Russia and undermine Moscow's efforts to regain its centrality through soft power and military coercion. For others, such as Belarus, it was an opportunity to reinstate these dependencies, encouraging Russia to further look for opportunities to cultivate allegiances through lucrative oil and gas deals, and military bases across the wider post-Soviet space. The fruits of these divergent reorientations are serving as an important counterpoint to the Russo-centric inclinations of Western academia, which tended to view the USSR as a monolith and, willingly or unwittingly, reinforced coloniality in relation to the post-Soviet periphery before the full-scale invasion of Ukraine (see (Chankseliani, 2017); (Khromeychuk, 2022); (Kuzhabekova, 2020)).

Looking forward into the future, it is clear that de-Sovietization is evolving as a globally significant discourse, which requires comprehensive critical inquiry that extends beyond the borders of the post-Soviet states. Further investigating different layers and contexts of de-Sovietization would allow the global scholarly community to discover complex drivers and blockers of transformations. Understanding them

would help in analyzing closed and authoritarian regimes around the world, as well as those experiencing democratic decline and descent into post-truth politics. The Derridean perspective on the ceaseless unpeeling of layers of understanding should be employed more intensively to generate more and deeper questions that challenge the established hierarchies and dogmas of post-Soviet knowledge.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Shchepetylnykova Liz: Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Oleksiyenko Anatoly V.:** Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Funding acquisition, Writing – review & editing.

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